

Lab: Crafting Your Inventive Pitch

Objective

Develop a complete communication package for your invention idea: a structured narrative, visual communication artifacts, an elevator pitch, and a practice patent claim. By the end of this lab, you will have a multi-format communication toolkit and the experience of adapting your message for different audiences.

Materials / Prerequisites

- Your own invention idea or project
- Paper and pen/markers for sketching
- A timer
- A willing listener (in person or remote) for the pitch practice
- Completed reading of Module 07: The Inventive Pitch

Part 1: Audience Model Analysis (10 minutes)

Before communicating, model your audience. The single most common mistake in invention communication is talking about what you know rather than addressing what the audience needs to know. Effective communication begins with empathy — building an explicit model of what the audience currently believes, what they care about, and what would need to change in their understanding for them to appreciate your invention. This is Active Inference applied to social cognition: you are constructing a generative model of another person's generative model, then designing actions (words, images, demonstrations) to update it.

Step 1 (5 min): Choose your primary audience for this exercise (investor, technical peer, potential user, or general public). Describe their generative model — what they currently believe about the problem your invention addresses:

Target audience:

Write your response here

What they currently believe about the problem:

Write your response here

What they currently believe about existing solutions:

Write your response here

What they would predict about your invention before hearing about it (their prior):

Write your response here

What key prediction errors will your pitch need to generate to update their model?

Write your response here

Step 2 (5 min): Identify the biggest gap between your model and your audience's model:

Aspect	What I Know / Believe	What My Audience Knows / Believes	The Gap
The problem			

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

| | The solution approach |

Write your response here

|

Write your response here

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Write your response here

| | **Why it matters** |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

| | **How it works** |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Part 2: Build the Invention Narrative (15 minutes)

The six-part invention narrative (setup, tension, insight, solution, evidence, vision) is not just a presentation format — it is a model-alignment protocol. Each part performs a specific cognitive operation on the audience: the setup activates their existing model, the tension creates a prediction error that their model cannot resolve, the insight provides a model update that resolves the error, the solution demonstrates the updated model's predictions, the evidence confirms those predictions, and the vision extends the model into the future. By following this structure, you manage the audience's learning process rather than simply dumping information.

Construct your story using the six-part structure from the module.

Setup — Prior Model (2 min): Describe the world as it currently exists. What is the status quo? Who is affected?

Write your response here

Tension — Prediction Error (2 min): What specific failure of the current situation motivates your invention? Why is the status quo inadequate?

Write your response here

Insight — Model Update (3 min): What is the key insight that makes your invention possible? What did you see or understand that others missed?

Write your response here

Solution — New Predictions (3 min): Describe your invention and how it works. What does the updated model predict?

Write your response here

Evidence — Prediction Confirmation (3 min): What evidence supports your invention? Test results, prototyping outcomes, user reactions, comparable examples?

Write your response here

Vision — Future Predictions (2 min): What does the world look like with your invention widely adopted?

Write your response here

Part 3: Visual Communication (12 minutes)

Visual communication is not optional — it is essential. Research on cognition consistently shows that visual information is processed faster, remembered longer, and understood more accurately than verbal information. For inventions, which often involve spatial relationships, temporal sequences, and causal mechanisms, visual communication provides information channels that words cannot access. You do not need to be an artist. Rough sketches with clear labels communicate more effectively than polished prose. The goal is to make the invisible visible — to give your audience perceptual evidence that their visual system can process directly.

Create three visual artifacts that communicate different aspects of your invention.

Visual 1 — System Diagram (4 min): Draw a diagram showing the components of your invention and how they relate. Label each component and connection. This should answer "What are the parts and how do they connect?"

Describe or reference your diagram:

Write your response here

Visual 2 — Before/After Comparison (4 min): Create a side-by-side sketch or description showing the situation BEFORE your invention and AFTER. This should make the value proposition visually obvious.

Before:

Write your response here

After:

Write your response here

Visual 3 — Storyboard (4 min): Draw or describe 4-6 panels showing a user experiencing your invention from first encounter to successful use. Each panel should be one moment in time.

Panel	Scene Description	What the User Experiences
1		

Write your response here

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Write your response here

|| 2 |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

|| 3 |

Write your response here

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|| 4 |

Write your response here

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|| 5 |

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|| 6 |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Part 4: The Elevator Pitch (10 minutes)

The elevator pitch is the most compressed form of invention communication — a 30-second to 2-minute summary that conveys the core value proposition under extreme time constraint. Its importance extends far beyond actual elevator encounters: the ability to articulate your invention concisely and compellingly is a test of how well you understand it. If you cannot explain your invention in 60 seconds, it usually means your own generative model contains ambiguities, redundancies, or unnecessary complexity. The pitch-writing process often reveals these issues, making it a valuable self-diagnostic tool as well as a communication device.

Step 1 (5 min): Write a 60-second elevator pitch for your invention. It should include: the problem (1-2 sentences), the insight (1 sentence), the solution (2-3 sentences), and the ask or vision (1 sentence). Time yourself reading it aloud — edit until it fits in 60 seconds.

Your elevator pitch:

Write your response here

Word count:

Write your response here

Time when read aloud:

Write your response here

Step 2 (5 min): Deliver your pitch to one other person (in person, by phone, or by video). After delivering it, ask them to tell you what they understood. Document:

What the listener understood correctly:

Write your response here

What the listener misunderstood or missed:

Write your response here

What question did they ask first?

Write your response here

What does their response tell you about the gap between your model and theirs?

Write your response here

Part 5: Practice Patent Claim (13 minutes)

Patent claims are the most precise form of invention communication. While narratives and pitches are designed to persuade, patent claims are designed to define — they specify exactly what the invention is, no more and no less. Writing a patent claim forces a level of clarity about your invention that no other communication format demands. You must specify the essential components (what cannot be removed without destroying the invention), the relationships between them (how they interact), and the result (what the combination achieves that the components alone do not). This exercise is not about creating a legally valid patent claim but about experiencing how formal specification sharpens your understanding of your own invention.

Step 1 (5 min): Write a simplified independent claim for your invention. Use this structure:
"A [type of thing] for [function], comprising: [component A]; [component B]; wherein [component A] is [related to] [component B] such that [result]."

Your independent claim:

Write your response here

Step 2 (4 min): Write two dependent claims that add specificity:

Dependent claim 1 (specifying a component):

Write your response here

Dependent claim 2 (specifying a method or material):

Write your response here

Step 3 (4 min): Reflect on the claim-writing exercise:

What did writing the claim force you to clarify about your invention?

Write your response here

What aspects of your invention were hardest to describe in claim language?

Write your response here

What is the "Markov blanket" of your invention — the minimal boundary that separates it from everything else?

Write your response here

Discussion / Debrief Questions

1. When you delivered your elevator pitch, what was the biggest gap between what you intended to communicate and what the listener understood? How would you modify the pitch to close that gap?
2. The module describes the "curse of knowledge" — the inventor's difficulty in predicting what the audience does not know. Did you experience this during the lab? What assumptions did you make about your audience's knowledge that turned out to be wrong?
3. Which communication format (narrative, visual, pitch, patent claim) was most difficult for you? What does this tell you about which aspects of your generative model are hardest to externalize?
4. The before/after visual comparison is often the most effective single communication artifact. Was your before/after compelling? What could make the contrast sharper?
5. Patent claims force extreme precision about what your invention IS and IS NOT. Did the claim-writing exercise change how you think about the boundaries of your invention? Did it reveal ambiguities you had not noticed?